

Phillip Olarte

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PRODUCT LEADERSHIP, DESIGN ENGINEERING | UX, HCI & AI

Building AI technology. Designing how people experience it. Helping organizations put it to work.

Product and UX leader with 15 years of experience building enterprise platforms, leading multidisciplinary teams, and translating emerging technology into usable products. Led a 10-person team delivering a research and reporting platform for Fortune 500 clients, led a 28-person team producing an immersive technology-enabled live experience to fivefold revenue in six weeks, and increased knowledge-tool adoption tenfold at the Ford Foundation. Combines product strategy, user research, hands-on prototyping, and AI interaction design, supported by a 2025 master's degree from NYU Tandon.

EXPERIENCE

Storyverse | New York, NY 2025–Present

Founder and Principal · Technology and Experience Design

- Lead a studio creating AI and immersive experiences across digital media, live performance, and physical space. Directed four initiatives and a 28-person team, including the production of AETHER; grew revenue fivefold in six weeks.
- Developed embodied AI MAIA: a locally hosted, multimodal AI experience integrating computer vision, speech recognition, a language model, and voice synthesis. Evaluated the experience with 37 participants and refined usability, privacy, trust, and conversational behavior. Engineered a virtual version for online use.
- Evaluate models, APIs, and vendors for usability, data handling, cost, latency, and deployment fit; create workflows for personalized content and team production.

BoardLens.ai | Remote 2026

AI Interaction Design Lead

- Designed research and synthesis workflows for a decision-support product for board members, including document source attribution and confidence cues that help people interpret AI outputs.
- Designed, iterated, and deployed the product website using Next.js and Three.js, incorporating visitor analytics to understand engagement.

BSR, Business for Social Responsibility | Remote 2021–2025

Head of Product, Materiality

- Led a 10-person product, design, and engineering team to deliver the organization's first unified Materiality platform for research, reporting, and strategic planning.
- Ran research and alignment workshops and translated more than 100 jurisdictional requirements into workflows, prototypes, and an enterprise platform for consultants and Fortune 500 clients.
- Presented design iterations weekly and taught and mentored developers and designers on design standards, technical requirements, and product goals.

ChalkNotes | New York, NY 2019–2021

Co-Founder and Head of Product

- Created a mobile discovery app and no-code authoring tools that enabled universities, cultural institutions, influencers, and nontechnical partners to build location-based storytelling experiences independently.
- Led field research and usability testing; designed high-contrast interfaces and audio-first interactions that reduced screen time by 60%. Products were used in work with Columbia University, Monticello, and the Chelsea Music Festival.

Ford Foundation | New York, NY

2016–2019

Information Management Specialist · Product and UX Design

- Modernized knowledge discovery for grantmakers managing a \$600 million portfolio; increased adoption tenfold through research, information architecture, search redesign, and workflow improvements.
- Led training workshops connecting IT capabilities with program teams' needs, helping nontechnical staff understand and use institutional knowledge tools.
- Partnered with visiting Google researchers to evaluate machine learning and semantic search and translate findings into practical tools for nontechnical staff.

TAU Investment Management | New York, NY

2013–2016

Head of TAU Innovations · Lead Product Designer

- Led TAU Innovations and built Retovian, a cross-platform supply-chain transparency product. Conducted research across four continents and designed for limited connectivity and users with little tablet experience.
- Supported early work on Transparentem, an independent spin-off, designing secure information tools for investigators and whistleblowers; findings helped companies halt millions of dollars in purchases from factories violating human rights.

Synthenai | New York, NY

2011–2014

Founder and Principal · Product and Digital Transformation Consulting

- Led product strategy, UX, software adoption, cloud implementation, and technical assessment across more than 40 B2B and B2C engagements, including interim CTO and CPO roles.
- Redesigned the purchase experience for a distressed e-commerce platform, contributing to a subsequent acquisition valued above \$12 million.
- Conducted technical due diligence for a proposed \$200 million investment in the Detroit–Windsor Tunnel, assessing technology, security, data integrity, and usability.

EDUCATION

New York University Tandon School of Engineering | M.S., Emerging Technologies (focus: AI and HCI), 2025

Nielsen Norman Group UX Master Certificate, 2018; Specializations in Interaction Design, User Testing Research, and User Experience Management

Catholic University of America Bachelor of Music, 2006

SELECTED SPEAKING AND PUBLICATIONS

Interactive AI Manifesto - Eight Lines in the Sand, THE MAIA PROJECT · 2025

Best Practices for Mixed Reality Experience Design in an Open World, UX COLLECTIVE · 2023

Narrative-Driven Mixed Reality · NY MEDIA LAB · 2022

Product Design and Mentorship on Startup Life · ROMANIA DEVELOPER COMMUNITY · 2021

SKILLS & TECHNOLOGIES

Learning & Adoption: Workshop facilitation, technology training, mentoring, digital fluency

AI & Emerging Technology: Generative and multimodal AI, RAG, local inference, computer vision, mixed reality

Design & Research: Figma, Framer, UX research, usability testing, accessibility, design systems

Creative Media: Adobe Creative Cloud, Final Cut Pro, Blender, Unity, TouchDesigner, spatial audio

Development: Python, PyTorch, React, Next.js, TypeScript, APIs, Arduino, Raspberry Pi, C++